

A Question of CONSCIENCE

The prime minister has announced an impressive list of projects in social development and Rahul Gandhi never misses an opportunity to champion the Dalit cause. Are the UPA ministers on social duty up to the challenge?

By Priya Sahgal

Mahatma Gandhi said India lives in its villages. The Gandhis—Sonia and her son Rahul—know that's where the votes are as they reach out to the 'other' India. With Manmohan Singh, the great liberaliser-turned-social spender as its mascot, the Congress had weaved a winning election campaign around a farmers' loan waiver and an employment guarantee scheme. Once in government, it wants to continue what it clearly sees as a winning formula. The *kurta* and sneakers-clad Rahul is travelling across the country dining with the Dalits, and sleeping with the tribals. The mother too has been accused of turning Manmohan's Government into an NGO. With their people-first policies, the Congress troika is wooing the *aam aadmi* promising him the entire hundred paise of that famous rupee that gets devalued to as little as 15 paise by the time it reaches the grassroots because of corruption. No other government has given so much lip service to the politics of poverty as this one. The spin around the



HIS CLOSE INTERACTION WITH DALITS HAS EARNED RAHUL GANDHI A LOT OF PRAISE